The exhibition “Architects of Liberation: Modernism in West Africa” follows architecture throughout West Africa after they gained independence from Britain during a time period of decolonization and liberation. As I walked through the exhibit, there was a common recurring theme of modernism with architecture that followed simple shapes like triangles and circles. This was interesting to see because you could really see how powerful the modernism movement was. Although the architects who worked on the projects in the exhibition may not have been trying to specifically replicate the style from European nations, the idea that progressive and modern motifs work to create similar shapes, ideas, and designs in not only architecture but other forms of design throughout different countries was compelling.

One specific object that I kept on thinking about while looking at the architecture projects from the exhibition was Cradle by Peter Keler. Although it was from Bauhaus, the reduced geometry to simple shapes such as circles and triangles was a common motif throughout the exhibition. One object that particularly reminded me of the Cradle were the African pavilions, grouped as “Africa Place” during Expo 67, the 1967’s world's fair in Montreal. The shapes of the pavilions were basically made of all triangles. Continuing the triangular shapes, the Centre International du Commerce Exterieur du Senegal (International Center for Foreign Trade, CICES) was another very important landmark of West African modernism. Even the poster promoting the second Foire Internationale de Dakar used triangles as graphics, highlighting how geometric modernist design was in West Africa. I feel like these projects heavily align with modernist beliefs in having simple shapes and clean lines which could have been influenced by the French architects who worked on a lot of the big projects. The CICES was designed by French architects Jean-François Lamoureux and Jean-Louis Marin. Commissioned by the president of Senegal, these French architects may have had the ideal modern look the president was looking for in order to create a new modern and progressive identity throughout the country.

